

PEER BENCHMARK · JULY 2025 – JUNE 2026

Where do major U.S. airlines lose on-time performance to causes they control?

American, Delta, United, JetBlue and Southwest · 4.47 million flights · official DOT data

Juan M. Valdez Galán · September 30, 2026

A fair comparison: same airport, same conditions

4.47M

flights, 12 months

Official BTS flight-level data for the five client airlines, validated month by month.

Controllable

what the airline can fix

Carrier-caused delay minutes and code-A cancellations (DOT Directive #40). Weather and air traffic are excluded.

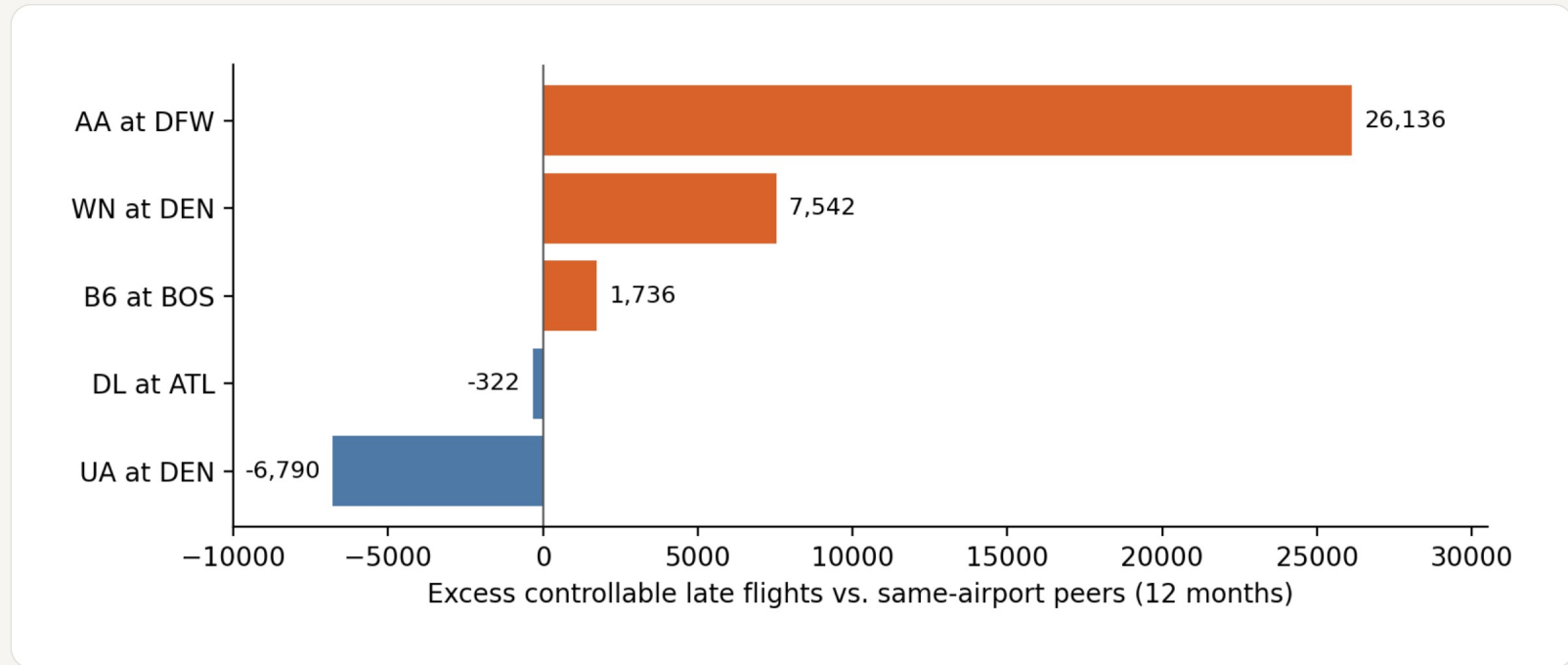
Peers

at the same airport

Each airline vs. the other clients departing the same airport: same weather, runways and air traffic control.

Validation: for 177,012 of 177,012 late flights tested, delay causes added up exactly to the arrival delay.

American at DFW has by far the largest controllable gap

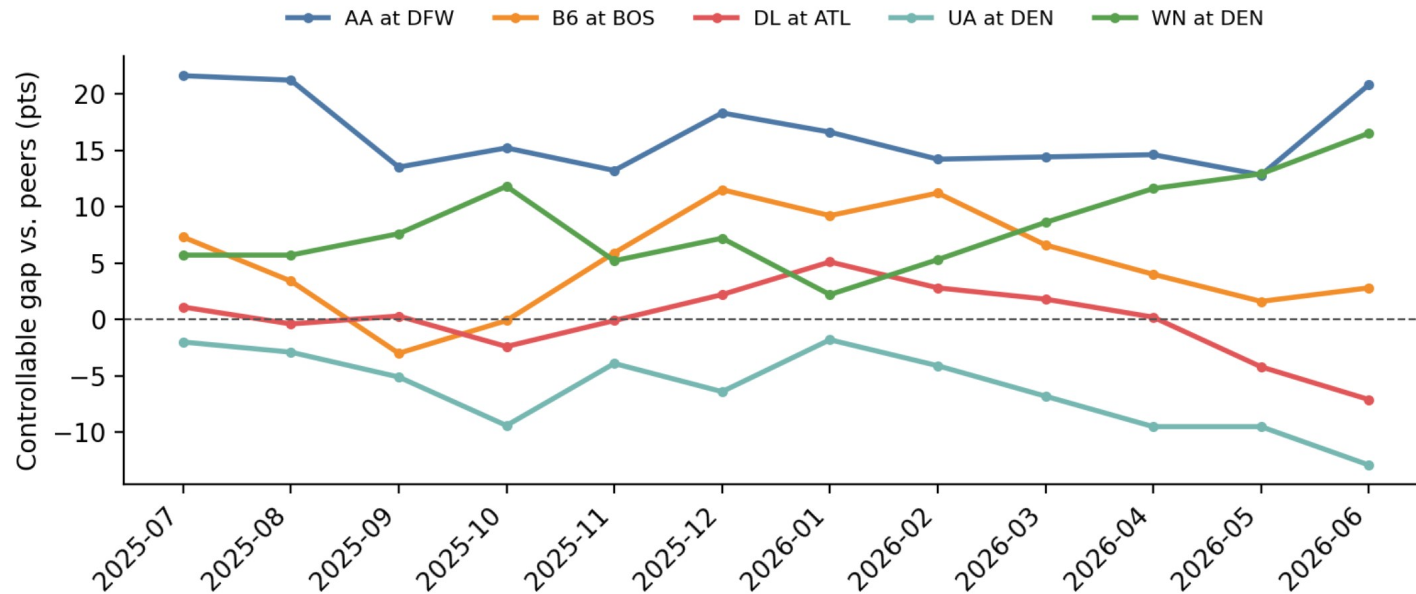


≈26,100

excess controllable late flights a year for AA at DFW: 25.2% vs. 8.8% for peers.

3.5x the next case (WN at DEN). UA at DEN is the best performer.

The gap is structural, not seasonal

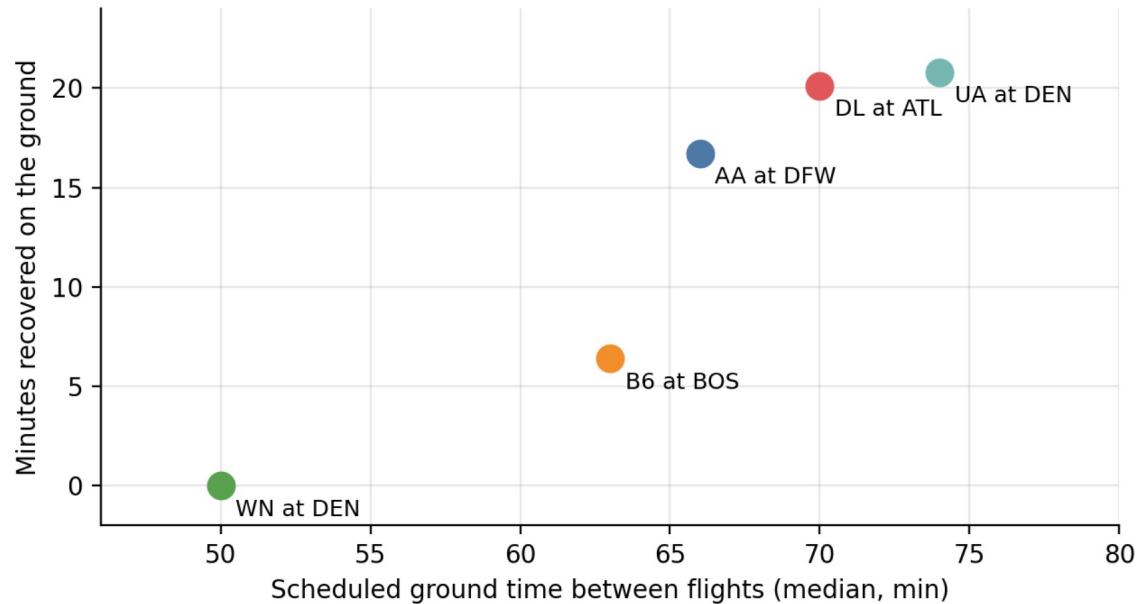


AA at DFW: worse than peers 12 of 12 months, never below +12.8 points.

WN at DEN: early warning — its three worst months are Apr–Jun 2026.

UA at DEN: better than peers every month.

More ground time between flights, more delay recovered



Denver, same airport:

United schedules

74 min

recovers 20.8

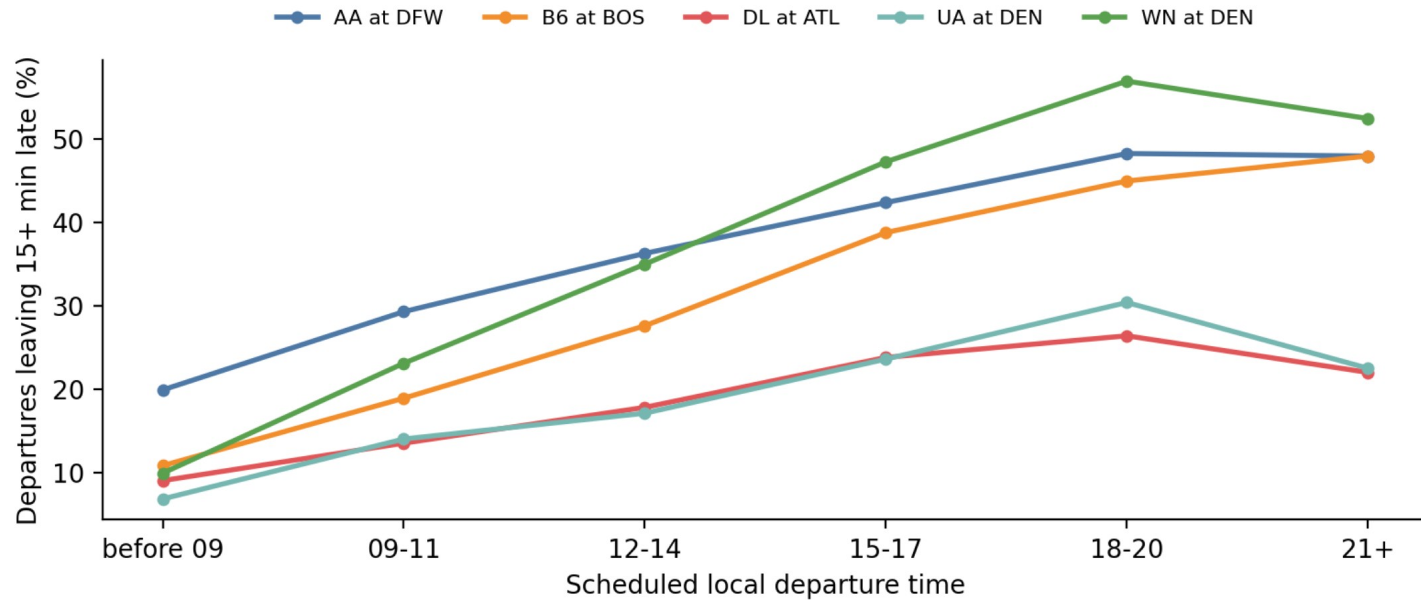
Southwest schedules

50 min

recovers 0

Same ranking for all five airlines: a strong, consistent relationship — not proof of causation.

Delay builds through the day — fastest for Southwest



WN: 9.9% → 57.0% late; only 45 min on the ground from 12:00 to 17:59, where recovery turns negative.

AA: flat 64–66 min schedule all day.

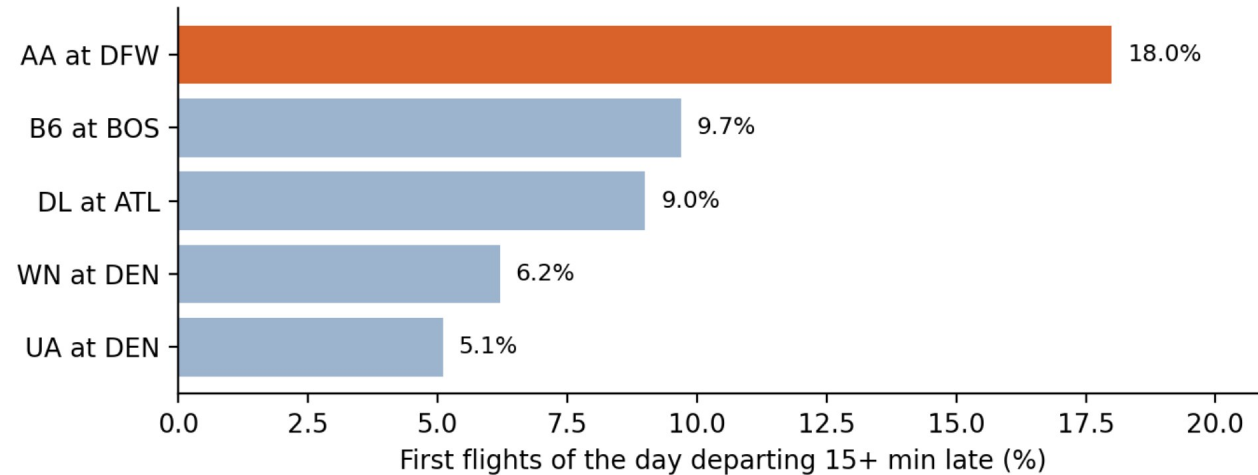
UA: widens to 82–97 min at midday and night.

American's problem starts with the first flight of the day

18.0%

of AA's first flights at DFW leave
15+ minutes late

vs. 5.1%–9.7% for the others. No inbound
aircraft means no propagation: this is
station readiness.



First flight = the aircraft's first operated flight that day. Verified: only 43%–89% of pre-09:00 departures are first flights, so this metric replaced the pre-09:00 rate.

Open question: cancel, or fly late?

American at DFW

0.25%

carrier cancellations vs. 0.83% for peers — the lowest — while having the largest controllable delay.

Delta at ATL

0.98%

carrier cancellations vs. 0.24% for peers — about 4x — with neutral controllable delay.

Consistent with opposite operating strategies. The data cannot show internal decisions: a question for the client, not a conclusion.

Recommendations

Airline	Action	How to measure
R1 · AA at DFW	Diagnose morning station readiness with internal data	First-flight late rate, toward DL's 9%
R2 · AA at DFW	Cut late inbound aircraft; review afternoon and evening ground times	Minutes recovered; monthly gap
R3 · WN at DEN	Pilot longer ground times on part of 12:00–17:59 rotations	Recovery in those bands; gap trend
R4 · B6 at BOS	Review turnaround process, focused on winter readiness	Minutes recovered; winter gap
R5 · DL and UA	Keep practices; UA at DEN as benchmark; DL to review carrier cancellations	Monthly gap; code-A rate

Trade-off: longer ground times mean fewer flights per aircraft per day — pilot before scaling.

Source: U.S. DOT, BTS Reporting Carrier On-Time Performance, Jul 2025 – Jun 2026 · Controllable = carrier-caused delay minutes and code-A cancellations

Limits, and how to keep this current

What the data cannot tell

- Crew vs. maintenance vs. ramp (all inside carrier delay)
- Secondary hubs and regional affiliates
- Overnight delay propagation
- Causation behind the ground-time relationship

Monthly monitoring

The pipeline and dashboard can be refreshed each month as BTS publishes new data, to track whether R1–R5 work.

Report, code and dashboard: github.com/donyvaldez/airline-delay-analysis